“Too Much Money.” “Spend Down.”

A worksheet for what your family has been told about Medicaid: who said it, what you have on paper, and what's still missing.

“She has too much money” is something somebody said. What Mom receives each month and what the deed says are facts, and facts with a paper behind them are what a professional can work from.

Write each thing you've been told in the words that were used, with a name beside it. Don't decide whether it's right. If you don't know something, write “don't know” and leave it.

What we've been told, and who said it

Everything your family has heard about Medicaid and Mom, as near to the original words as you can remember. Put a name and a rough date beside each one.

FOR EXAMPLE “She has too much money for Medicaid.” Someone in the admissions office, the week Mom moved in. “You'll have to spend down first.” A neighbor, whose father was in a nursing home in another state.

What we have on paper, and what is from memory

For Mom's income, her accounts, the house and her insurance: do you have a statement or a document, or are you going by what someone remembers? No totals needed.

FOR EXAMPLE Checking account: last month's statement, in the blue folder. The savings account David mentioned: no statement, he's going from memory. The house: we think it's in Mom's name. Haven't seen the deed.

The facts that aren't about money

Where Mom lives, where she is getting care now and what kind, what has been put in writing about the care she needs, and whether she is married.

FOR EXAMPLE Her own house, in the same town for decades. In the facility's rehab wing since the 3rd. The therapist said she needs help getting out of bed; we don't have that in writing yet.

What's missing

Papers nobody has found and facts nobody is sure of. Don't guess to fill a line.

FOR EXAMPLE No copy of the deed. Don't know whose names are on the savings account. Nobody remembers when Mom helped Karen with the down payment.

What we'd need to confirm, and who to ask

For each thing you were told, the question it leaves open and the person it goes to.

FOR EXAMPLE What “too much” was measured against, and whether it fits Mom's state: ask your Medicaid planner. What the admissions office meant by “spend down”: ask them, and write down what they say.

Who filled this in, and on which days

What this shows you

Three things: what your family has been told and by whom, how much of your picture rests on paper and how much on memory, and what you'd still need to confirm. It doesn't show whether anything you were told is right, and it doesn't show where Mom stands. Nothing here adds up to a score or a result. Medicaid rules vary by state, and nothing here is legal, financial or tax advice; those questions go to your Medicaid planner or the appropriate licensed professional.

Ready for the next step?

You've written down what you were told, with a name beside each thing, and you can see what still needs confirming. The planning interview picks up from there: it asks about the rest of your family's situation and gives you a free planning report you can bring to any conversation about paying for Mom's care.

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